

A Brief History of the Dreaded Office Cubicle

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FULL TEXT

By Nikil Saval

"Cubicle" has got to be one of the most efficient words in the English language. Nothing so swiftly conjures up such a feeling of dread and drudgery. "We don't have a lot of time on this Earth," says the cubicle-dwelling protagonist of the great cult film "Office Space" (1999). "We weren't meant to spend it this way."

In part because the cubicle has become such a despised symbol of a bad office job, the gray, felt-covered walls are starting to come down. More open office plans with fewer or no partitions (or even long picnic tables serving as desks) are now all the rage. The irony is that the open office was exactly what the creator of the cubicle was trying to save us all from.

That inventor was Robert Propst, a brilliant designer working in the 1960s for the office-furniture firm Herman Miller. He called the U.S. office "a wasteland" in 1960. "It saps vitality, blocks talent, frustrates accomplishment. It is the daily scene of unfulfilled intentions and failed effort."

The offices Propst so loathed were largely open, of the type we now see on "Mad Men": row after orthogonal row of serried desks, where accountants or typists clacked away from 9 to 5, often surrounded by a corridor of closed-door offices for managers and executives.

The 1960s witnessed the rise of an even more open plan: a new concept imported from Germany called the Bürolandschaft, or office landscape. It called for cultivated chaos: desks grouped together in pods across a sprawling floor plan, with sightlines blocked by tall ferns and soundscreens and not a private office in sight. This new, swirling design--meant to flatten hierarchies and ease communication--became a big hit with architects, planners and designers. Soon it was springing up all over Europe--and, after the first U.S. office landscape was installed in the headquarters of DuPont in 1967, across the U.S. as well.

The problem? People hated it. Open-office plans--then as now--mean noise, both visual and aural. People used to private offices couldn't concentrate because of all the chatter and typing. For all the supposed egalitarianism of the office landscape, managers usually allotted themselves more space than junior staff, and the creative use of screens and extra plants often let them carve out ad hoc private offices for themselves. By the 1970s, European workers' councils had rejected open-office plans, insisting that employees across the continent be granted private offices. In the U.S., however, the open-plan remained unchallenged--until Propst. He concluded that office workers needed autonomy and independence--and therefore offered a flexible, three-walled design that could be reshaped to any given need. Propst also felt that workers needed to stand as often as they sat, so he created storage space to encourage workers to get up. And he wanted offices to encourage "meaningful traffic" among workers. It was a startlingly utopian vision, and it forecast much of today's progressive office-design thinking.

His product, Action Office II, was a smash. Debuting in 1968, it consisted of three obtusely angled, hinged, fabric-wrapped walls--all to encourage a flexible office space that could be shaped as needed. Sylvia Porter of the New York Post gushed, "As a person who spent a working lifetime in the open spaces of a newspaper city room, I find the concept entirely appealing." In 1985, the World Design Conference named it the most successful design of the previous 25 years. In 1998, two years before Propst died, around 40 million Americans were working in what he estimated were 42 different versions of Action Office II.

He neglected to mention that they largely went by one name: the cubicle. The term had been used before--Frank

Wheeler in Richard Yates's 1961 novel "Revolutionary Road" works in a cubicle--but usually to mean small, more permanent, carrel-like workspaces. Propst's flexible design and disposable materials made the cubicle cheaper. The problems of the cubicle soon helped people forget the problems of the open office. In the 1980s and 1990s, giant mergers and mass layoffs of cubicle dwellers became commonplace. For workers shuttled from an office into a cubicle in a giant corporation formed from a merger, waiting out the days before being canned, the flimsy walls of the cubicle began to symbolize not independence and flexibility, as Propst had hoped, but transience, precariousness and the disposability of the American worker.

But here's the twist: Erstwhile cubicle denizens shoved forth into an open-office plan often confront many of the same feelings, perhaps even more intensely. Many workers I've spoken to in open offices find concentration and privacy elusive--and often miss their cubicles.

The real problem isn't the furniture; it is how the furniture represents the arbitrariness of power in the workplace. "The dark side of this is that not all organizations are intelligent and progressive," Propst said two years before he died.

"Lots are run by crass people who can take the same kind of equipment and create hellholes. They make little bitty cubicles and stuff people in them. Barren, rathole places...I never had any illusions that this was a perfect world."

Mr. Saval is an editor at n+1 and the author of "Cubed: A Secret History of the Workplace," just published by Doubleday.

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